

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world NewAgeGurus

By Justine Hardy |

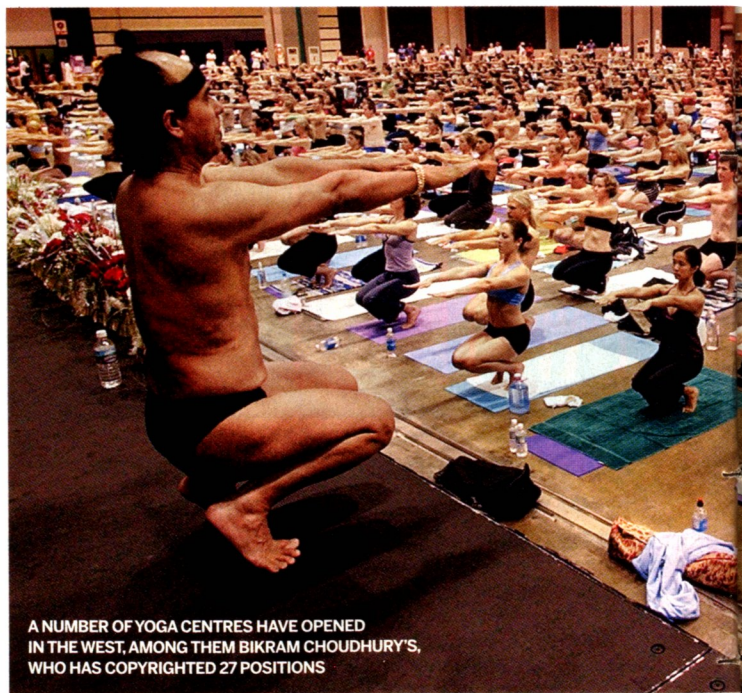
It is a staggering irony that we are now in the age of gigabyte gurus. The way of the Gurukul, the long pupillage of a child with a guru to establish if the child was even a worthy vessel of Vedic learning, has now been usurped by the Coca Cola factor. Years of preparing and honing a mind to the subtleties of the scriptures have been replaced by our impatience to get it all in one easy download, our need for instant gratification, and for not wanting to put in the earnest and ascetic legwork of decades of study and practice.

There is an apocryphal story about how Coke got its bottle. Sales were a bit slow after its invention in the late 19th century in Georgia, USA, as it was being sold from kegs by the glass. The solution came with two words of advice: 'bottle it', and so the legend began. The same idea has been applied to Indian philosophy. It was exported to the west and beyond, where it has been sprayed in Lycra and slick business ethos, branded, now sent right back here with a New Age spin, and all the bells and whistles of the media age. Whether it is the television yoga hit, Baba Ramdev, telling his vast audience to stop drinking Coca Cola and start standing on their heads, or one of the big designers launching a new range of yoga wear, there has been a seismic change in the whole spiritual scene over the past decade.

The new generation of gurus come in all shapes, sizes and from different schools. Their answers to life's eternal question range from: 'try adding a little more *haldi* to your food' via 'change your job, your house, your car, your wife,' to 'go and sit in Vipassana meditation for 10 days'. Cynics view this shift in the spiritual appetite as yet another example of the decline of the human condition to a state where only immediate results are acceptable. The hopeful see it as a collective hunger to reconnect with the core, the soul, the spirit, the silence, whichever term they prefer to use. The corporates see it as yet another marketing bandwagon to hitch themselves to, and there is a raft of teachers out there who are happy to be hitched. The headcount on yoga millionaires is increasing exponentially. As the number of 'corporate yogis' grows, some of the original teachers, those labelled as the ones

FAST FOOD for the Soul

Going beyond saffron robes and cloistered satsangs, gigabyte gurus are frontlining channels, promoting alternative cures and acquiring celebrity disciples



A NUMBER OF YOGA CENTRES HAVE OPENED IN THE WEST, AMONG THEM BIKRAM CHOUDHURY'S, WHO HAS COPYRIGHTED 27 POSITIONS

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- The last decade has seen the coming of age of TV evangelism in India, with a plethora of religious channels, about nine of them, featuring gurus and their teachings. Over 85 million people turn on and tune in to Baba Ramdev every day.
- Yoga now has a global reach. Worldwide, it has a \$225-billion market. At home, spiritualism seemed rooted in ritual. An INDIA TODAY survey in 2007 showed that about 43 per cent of the youth visit a place of worship once a week.